



Legend of the game: Muralitharan turned the fortunes of Sri Lankan cricket around with his guile and an insatiable appetite for wickets. AP

the likes of Anil Kumble and Harbhajan Singh around. But over the last few years, a strong pace battery has emerged, with Jasprit Bumrah and Mohammed Shami leading the pack. How do you see this shift?

In the 1990s, India had a very big spin force, but in the early 2000s, people like Zaheer (Khan) came into the team, and eventually, there were players like Shami, who developed the fast-bowling unit. Bumrah made a huge difference because he is so different from the rest, and he is just like our (Lasith) Malinga in Sri Lanka. His presence has benefitted the

team, and when you have a player like that, the youngsters want to be like him. A lot of people work hard and put in the effort to become fast bowlers. That's why, in India now, a lot of fast bowlers are coming in rather than spinners.

When Anil or Harbhajan was around, a lot of young spinners were following them, but now they are following the likes of Bumrah.

Do you feel Test cricket is more competitive these days?

Test cricket has changed over the last two decades because of T20s. The batters who play aggressively tend to do that in Test cricket. That's why they score quickly and get out quickly. I feel that's one of the reasons why you find results now.

Back in our time, there was a

theory that the openers would have to take the shine off the new ball, and then take about 30 to 40 overs to score 40-odd runs. They took time, and there were instances of teams scoring just 160 or 170 and losing five wickets despite batting for the entire day. So, the next day, the teams would come back and re-strategise.

The pitches are now also prepared for results. Those days, there were very good five-day wickets, and whichever team was good enough would win. That has changed, and that's why now it looks as if Test cricket is more competitive since matches finish early and we have results.

But in my opinion, Test cricket is dying. It's not because of the players who ultimately want to play the